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Human Rights Defender of the month: Pacifique Nininahazwe

25 May 2025.

HRDs of the Month (<https://defenddefenders.org/category/hrd-of-the-month/>), News (<https://defenddefenders.org/category/news/>)

Burundi (<https://defenddefenders.org/countries/burundi/>)

Pacifique Nininahazwe's journey as a human rights defender is intertwined with the work of

DefendDefenders, which has stood with him during the most challenging moments of his activism. As Chair of the *Forum pour le Renforcement de la Société Civile* (FORSC), Burundi's main civil society platform. Pacifique collaborated with DefendDefenders on several initiatives, including the landmark *Claiming Spaces* event in Bujumbura in 2014. This pivotal gathering laid the foundation for the establishment of the Burundian Coalition of Human Rights Defenders, where Pacifique played a role in its creation and later revitalisation.

“I came to know DefendDefenders during the second half of 2009. In November that year, they supported my evacuation and temporary relocation abroad. It was a very difficult period for FORSC and for me. This organisation taught me, and many other HRDs in Burundi, the very concept of a human rights defender, and everything related to their physical and digital security.”

Born on 18 June 1976 in Mparamirundi, in northern Burundi's Kayanza province, Pacifique was raised in a household grounded in justice and education, his father a judge, his mother a teacher. Early on, his sense of justice was stirred not by childhood fantasies but by stories of moral courage such as the biblical tale of Jesus defending a condemned woman.

“Every Sunday morning, we attended mass. I remember being struck by Jesus Christ's reaction when an adulterous woman was brought before him. As the crowd clamoured for her stoning, Jesus defended her, confounding her accusers with the words: ‘Let any one of you who is without sin be the first to throw a stone at her.’ I believe that even back then, this moment awakened something in me, the human rights defender I would later become.”

Like the image of Jesus saving a sinful woman, he has always been fascinated by the journeys of heroes who save their peoples and their countries. The legacy of Burundi's independence hero, Prince Louis Rwagasore. These formative influences, coupled with his father's encouragement to engage critically with current affairs, laid the groundwork for a lifetime of activism.

“A man's greatness is measured by his ability to reduce injustices, to serve others, and to fight for the dignity of every human being.”

This early moral compass, sharpened by exposure to political injustice and ethnic divisions, shaped his path. He went ahead to choose the faculty of law at university in order to acquire the knowledge that would enable him to combat injustices and provide him with the opportunity to defend the most vulnerable in society.

“Initially, I believed that law represented justice. But during the first weeks at the Faculty of Law, I was disillusioned when I realised that legal knowledge could be used just as easily by perpetrators of injustice as by those who fight against it. At the same time, I understood that knowing the law provides power, the power to resist, to change unjust situations, and to defend victims. Today, in the struggle for human rights, I know how wise that academic choice was.”

At the University of Burundi, in the shadow of the 1995 massacre of Hutu students, he co-founded FOCODE, bringing together students across ethnic lines to envision a peaceful and just Burundi. As a law student, he co-founded the *Forum pour la Conscience et le Développement* (FOCODE) in 2001, a civil society organisation that would grow into a leading voice for justice and democratic governance in Burundi.

In 2009, Pacifique became Chair of FORSC, Burundi's main civil society platform. He rose to national prominence when, as FORSC Chairperson, he publicly condemned the killing of a resident by a provincial governor's guard and called out the state's failure to protect its citizens from arbitrary arrest and extra-judicial executions. At that time, Pacifique declared that this death could not go unpunished and reminded the state of its responsibility to protect citizens in the face of such abuses.

That same year, he spearheaded the civil society campaign for justice following the assassination of Ernest Manirumva, Deputy Chairman of OLUCOME, who was investigating arms trafficking allegedly involving senior ruling party members. This campaign marked a turning point, bringing both international attention and heightened risks. 2009 became one of the darkest years in his activism, as he faced mounting threats and state repression.

“In November 2009, I received information about a plot to have me killed. I was briefly evacuated to Nairobi, Kenya. Around the same time, the Ministry of Interior temporarily banned FORSC, which I was heading. The ban was eventually lifted due to international pressure. The secret services orchestrated disinformation, stigmatisation, and intimidation campaigns against me, through pro-government media and even during Imbonerakure demonstrations.”

During the 2015 political crisis in Burundi, Pacifique became one of the most vocal civil society leaders against President Nkurunziza's third-term bid. Often appearing in international media and public forums to denounce repression and call for democratic reforms. His visibility and bold criticism of the regime made him a target. He survived an assassination attempt and

“During the 2015 demonstrations, a minister from the Nkurunziza government quietly warned me that plans for my assassination had been renewed. The government had been running smear campaigns to discredit me. All efforts were aimed at destroying the trust the Burundian people have in me. So far, these attempts have failed, the more I am attacked, the more public support I gain.”

While many thought exile would silence him, Pacifique instead strengthened his advocacy. In 2016, he launched #Ndondeza (“Help me find them”), a digital and grassroots campaign documenting enforced disappearances in Burundi. Through this initiative, he and his team at FOCODE provided families with answers and held authorities accountable. ***“Since launching this campaign, all Burundians have become aware of its existence. It's now difficult to find a report on the human rights situation in Burundi that doesn't mention enforced disappearances.”***

Despite this win, his work has come at immense personal cost, including prolonged separation from his children and relentless defamation by the regime.

“My children live under security discipline, almost like I do. They are victims of being born to me.”

His influence extends beyond Burundi, as he actively engages with regional and international mechanisms including the African Commission on Human and Peoples’ Rights (ACHPR), the United Nations Human Rights Council, and diplomatic actors to highlight the shrinking civic space in Burundi, the criminalisation of dissent, and the plight of exiled human rights defenders.

“Thanks to social media, I’ve managed to keep fighting for human rights in Burundi. I even feel more engaged in exile than I was back home. There’s no doubt that my commitment to this work has more than quadrupled since I went into exile.”

A 2010 Archbishop Desmond Tutu Fellow, Pacifique is recognised as a courageous voice of conscience. His influence goes beyond advocacy; he is an organiser, strategist, and coalition-builder whose work continues to inspire many

Today, as Burundi continues to grapple with political and human rights challenges, Pacifique Nininahazwe holds firm to his hope for change:

“I’m fighting for a just and reconciled Burundi, one whose democracy is rooted in the rule of law, and where the rights and freedoms of every citizen are respected. Burundi has suffered immensely, and sadly, more suffering lies ahead. But Burundians are a very resilient and courageous people. They give their leaders opportunities to change, but they always rise up when least expected. I have no doubt that the day will come when they say a loud ‘NO’ to dictatorship.”

MORE NEWS:

Reflections on the 60th session of the UN Human Rights Council (<https://defenddefenders.org/reflections-on-the-60th-session-of-the-un-human-rights-council/>)

The UN’s liquidity crisis and broader funding cuts to international agencies and the non-profit sector continue to affect human rights work worldwide. It is estimated that the UN’s budget will decrease by 15% in 2026. The UN’s human rights pillar, which was already chronically under-funded compared to the other two pillars (development and peace & security), with less than 5% of the organisation’s budget, risks being disproportionately affected.

Chioma: Empowering the Next Generation Online (<https://defenddefenders.org/chioma-empowering-the-next-generation-online/>)

Chioma was part of the 2023 cohort of DefendDefenders' Safe Sisters fellowship, the flagship programme of DefendDefenders Tech which offers digital safety and security training to women human rights (WHRDs), journalists and media workers. "Safe Sisters Fellowship was a 360-degree turnaround in my career, in my life. Everything about me turned 360 degrees after that encounter. After the fellowship, there was a chain of positive events, one after another, until today, I can proudly introduce myself as a digital security advocate."

Somalia: international support and scrutiny should continue despite UN shift (<https://defenddefenders.org/somalia-scrutiny-should-continue-despite-un-shift/>)

After the UN Human Rights Council changed its approach to

Burundi: international human rights scrutiny continues (<https://defenddefenders.org/burundi-human-rights-scrutiny-continues/>)

Ten years after the unresolved 2015 crisis, and with no

Sudan: as war rages, UN extends human rights investigations (<https://defenddefenders.org/sudan-as-war-rages-un-extends-investigations/>)

Meeting in Geneva today, the UN Human Rights Council adopted

DefendDefenders welcomes new members to the team (<https://defenddefenders.org/defenddefenders-welcomes-new-members-to-the-team-2/>)

We are thrilled to welcome three new members to our team: Ainobusingye Praise, Daniel Martin Ikosiot, and Floor Veldman. Joining us as fellows, each one brings a unique experience and talent that will support us in enhancing our mandate to protect and promote the work of human rights defenders.

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